

EXEC UTIVE

The Clean Network: The Tech War's Winning Hand

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Following years of uncoordinated U.S. government attempts to curb data security risks from foreign actors, the Clean Network was formed in May 2020. The initiative's subsequent global campaign came in quick succession from the U.S. Undersecretary of State to the Trump Administration, Keith Krach, was under pressure to stop Huawei—the world's prized technology giant—and its seemingly inevitable market domination of fifth-generation (5G) cellular network infrastructure. But what is the Clean Network, and why is it one of the largest accomplishments of recent U.S. politics?

7 The Clean Network Background

Months prior to the initiative's formation, Huawei had announced 91 commercial 5G contracts globally, 47 being in Europe. The lack of an end-to-end competitive product and other competitive advantages led many telecommunication firms to overlook the well-known risks of Chinese Communist Party (CCP) access to Huawei data and proclaim, "business is business." These cyber espionage risks include disrupting critical networks and accessing customer data and communications. Chinese National Intelligence Law enables these firms—as firms—namely Huawei and ZTE—must "support, assist, and cooperate with national intelligence agencies." How would you feel if a Western adversary had access to data ranging from your text logs to top-level government communications? While cyber espionage is undoubtedly not limited to China, there are many reasons why they are not internationally trusted. These reasons include the nation's authoritarian structure, state-vendor links, discovered security vulnerabilities, and past allegations. Clearly, Chinese 5G products represent a significant national security issue for all corners of the world.

Initial acceptance and lack of risk mitigation strategies towards Huawei and ZTE from much of the West led to a range of risks adverse to democratic-world interests. This was especially problematic for security relationships like the North American Treaty Organization (NATO) military alliance. NATO claims that its communications could be compromised through backdoor access points if one member used Huawei 5G

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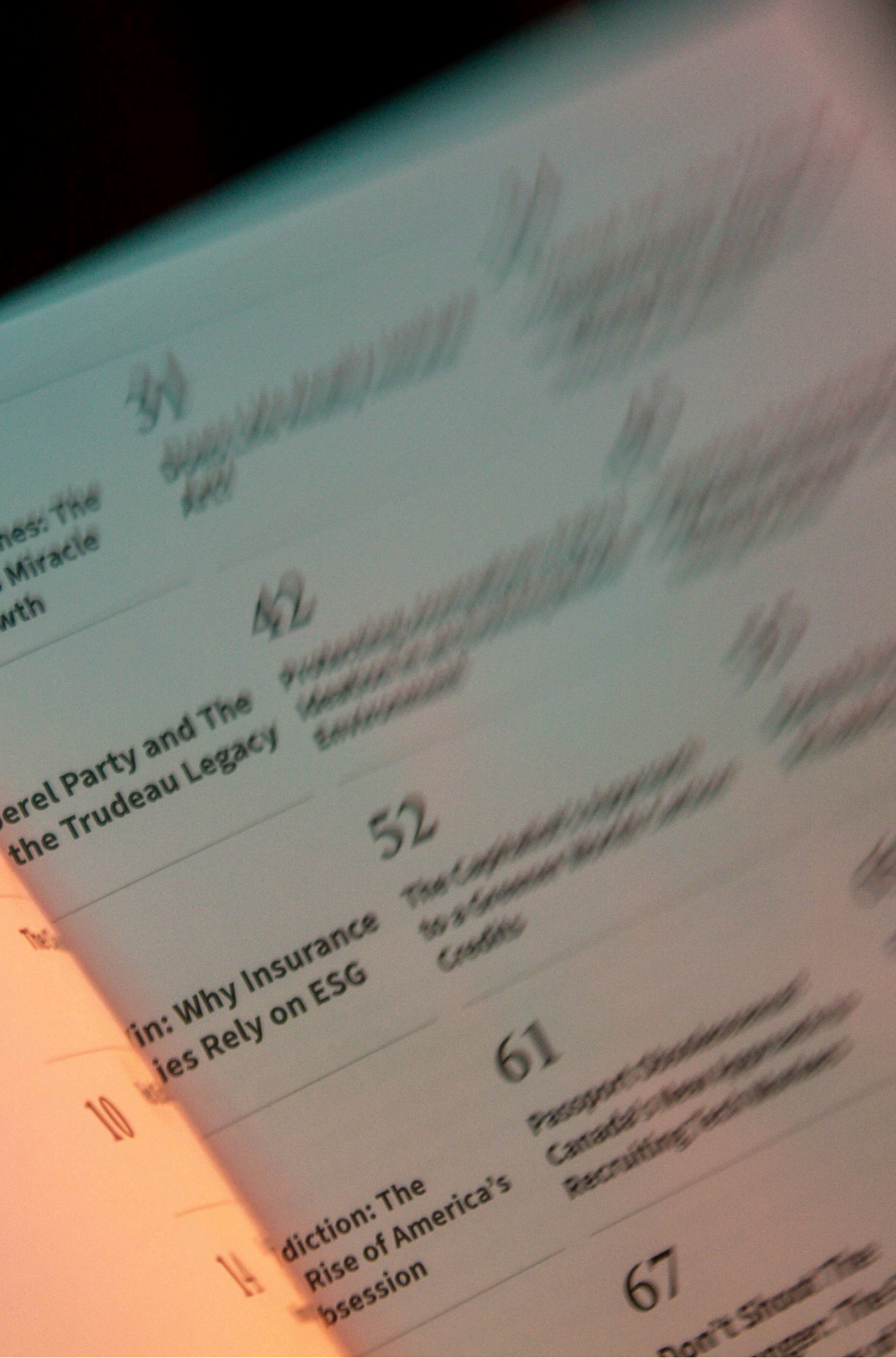
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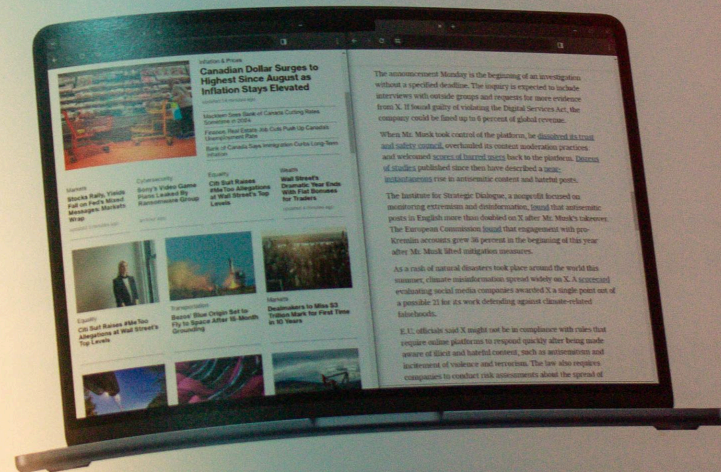
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